



The sight of *thousands of animals* moving across a landscape is one of the wonders of the world. But why do they do it? It's not for a change of scenery—many are driven by a biological need to find food, water, or mates. This type of annual movement is called *migration*.

Many migrating animals travel long distances to reach their *feeding* or *breeding* grounds. Most travel the same route there and back, *some without stopping*.



Getting ready

Long-distance travelers have to be in peak condition before setting off. Many species don't stop along the way for food and water, so they have to build up reserves of fat to provide them with energy.



Changing seasons

Most migrations are seasonal and occur because the lack of food or water makes it impossible for the animal to stay in one place. Those that move to find food include geese, reindeer, and whales. Humpback whales make some of the longest journeys. Their feeding grounds are not the best place to breed, so they move from the poles to warmer waters to have their calves.

Time to go

While some animals only move when they are forced to, others have a built-in instinct for when it is time to set off. Changes in day length or seasonal weather conditions can affect food supplies or make it too hot, cold, wet, or dry for the animal. If the animal can't adapt to the changes, for example, by growing a thicker coat or hibernating, it has to migrate.



ONE-WAY TICKET



American monarch butterflies head south to Mexico to spend the winter. As they start the return trip, they mate and die. The next generation continues the journey, but it is often the third or even fourth generation that finally makes it home.



Salmon spend their adult lives out at sea, but when they reach breeding age they journey back to the freshwater streams where they hatched to lay their own eggs. Exhausted by the effort, they die after spawning.

Giving birth

Animals do their best to protect their young, so many migrate to places that offer shelter or the chance to raise their offspring away from predators. Emperor penguins walk many miles into Antarctica and endure harsh conditions to bring up their chicks safely.



trip from *pole to pole* every year.